



▲ The application manager window



▲ Updates from your 'connections'

it's basically Ubuntu with some modifications. Specifically, it's based on Ubuntu Netbook Remix (UNR) version 9.04. In fact, the default login sound, which seems quite out of place in the modern-looking Jolicloud, hasn't even been changed.

Jolicloud keeps the launcher application and basic design of UNR v9.04, too. If you're not familiar with the older UNR, this basically means three things:

- First, all your applications are sorted into category-based tabs. Clicking on a tab displays a page with large icons for each application. A single click opens the application. Additionally, on the right of the screen are links to your home folder, documents folder, and so on. These folder links are not as well integrated, though, and open up an instance of Nautilus.
- Second, all windows are maximised (or should be). Rather than letting users place applications side by side, UNR forces users to work with one application at a time. This actually makes a lot of sense with some applications, because there really isn't enough space to work with multiple applications on a netbook. Other applications, though, don't work as well this way.
- Finally, the windows list only displays the full name of the current application. The panel at the top of your screen puts all the instances you're

running neatly into tabs of icons, making for seamless switching between applications.

A deeper look into the OS

JoliCloud uses Mozilla's Prism Web runtime and UNR to deliver a Web-centric Linux environment that is easy to use. The platform and its associated Web service are at an early stage of development and as mentioned earlier, are currently in closed alpha testing.

JoliCloud introduces new features with a new interface for installing applications. For starters, the developers have had the sense not to offer applications like GIMP, which really doesn't work well with the concept of 'one window at a time'. More importantly though, JoliCloud makes installing applications a one-click process. After clicking the install button under any application, it gets added to a queue of software updates and installs. This means no more waiting for Synaptic to close before performing updates.

Even cooler, though, is the integration of Web applications into the application area. There is no distinction between standard applications and Web applications (which run in Mozilla Prism). When you are offline, these applications will still launch, but can't do much, unless they use Google Gears to store data offline.

However, the extensive use of Prism largely defines the philosophy behind the JoliCloud user experience. Web applications are treated like conventional software—each one is launched in its own window and process. This is perhaps similar to the model that Google will pursue with its upcoming Chrome OS platform.

The only significant complaint I have with JoliCloud is that there are some rough spots in the theme. It looks great in all the screenshots on the JoliCloud website, but there are some hidden (and not so hidden) unthemed parts.

For example, the volume control is taken straight out of default GNOME with no theming. It integrates just fine with Ubuntu, but it doesn't look right with the dark, modern look of JoliCloud.

JoliCloud centres on a directory of applications that can be sorted by genre, release date, and popularity. To download or remove them from your computer, just click on their icon and it does the rest. Jolicloud groups both Web apps and software programs under the same name umbrella, and both are added and removed from your system in the same manner. There're also normal Add and Remove programs tools just like you get in Windows, but it's easier to use them from JoliCloud's rounded and simplistic interface.